

Chapter – 8: Unity in Diversity, or ‘Many in the One’

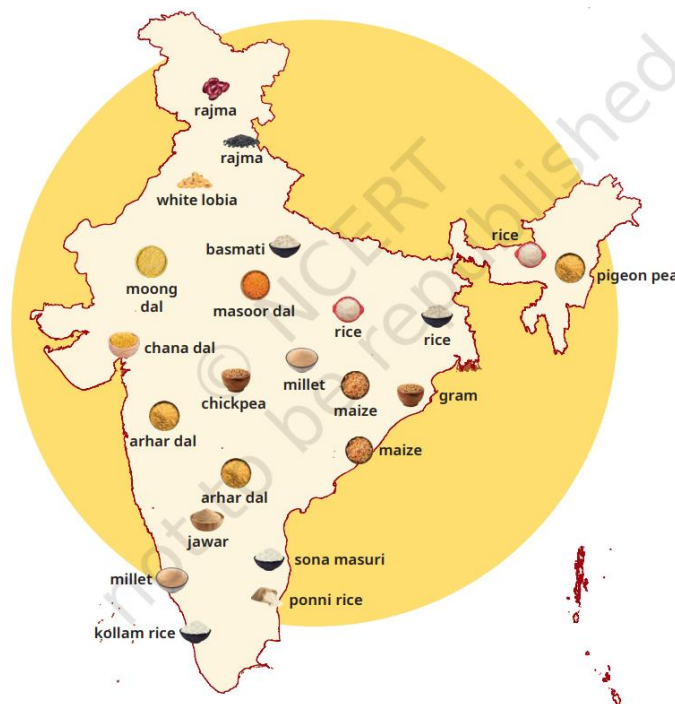
Oh, grant me my prayer, that I may never lose the bliss of the touch of the one in the play of the many. — Rabindranath Tagore

... The principle of unity in diversity which has always been normal to [India] and its fulfilment the fundamental course of her being and its very nature, the Many in the One, would place her on the sure foundation of her Swabhava and Swadharma. — Sri Aurobindo

A Rich Diversity

- Travel India – by train – changing landscapes – diff. food, dresses, languages, etc.
- Your own region – people – India's other parts – diff. customs, traditions
- India's rich diversity – usually – 1st thing – attract visitors
- 1.4 billion + population – 18 % of world population – diversity – not surprising
- Late 20th century – Anthropological Survey of India – national org. – massive survey – ‘People of India project’ – 4635 communities – all States
- This survey – counted – 325 languages – 25 scripts
- Also obs. – many Indians – migrants – not living with original community
- Diversity – very beautiful – BUT – making sense – not easy
- Century ago – British historian Vincent Smith – thought –
 - How to write history – such diversity
- Answer –
 - India offers – **unity in diversity**

Food for All



- You might have eaten – food – diff. regions
- No. of dishes – India – 1000s
- Certain food grains – common – every part – rice, barley, wheat, pearl millet (bajra), sorghum (jowar), finger millet (ragi), dals, grams, etc.

- All these – ‘staple grains’ – basic food – most Indians
- Common spices – turmeric, cumin, cardamom, ginger
- Same ingredients (unity) – no. of combinations (diversity) – endless variety of dishes

Textiles and Clothing

- Every region, community – own styles – clothing, dresses
- Yet – commonality – some traditional Indian dresses
- Obvious example – plain length of cloth – sari – worn – most parts – made of diff. fabrics – mostly – cotton, silk – nowadays – synthetic fabrics
- Banarasi, Kanjivaram, Paithani, Patan Patola, Muga, Mysore – famous types – silk saris
- Unstitched piece – 100s of varieties – diff. methods – weaving, designing
- Some designs – part of cloth – others – printed after weaving
- Finally – endless variations – colours – produced by – diff. pigments
- Sari – long history – stone **relief** – Vaishali (Bihar) – few centuries BCE
- Very long time – India – produced – finest cotton – Indian textiles – exported – far away – even Europe
- One type – printed cotton – chintz – so popular – 17th century Europe – European dresses’ sale – dropped sharply
- Protect own products – Britain, France – ban import – chintz from India
- Many ways – wear Sari – vary – region to region – OR – community to community
- New ways – draping it – still invented
- Past centuries – travelers – wondered – simplicity, economy, diverse ways for wearing it
- Women – use sari – other things – filtering, shade against sun, etc.



Festivals Galore

- Festivals – immense variety – few common ones – celebrated – same time – diff. names
- Makar Sankranti – beginning – harvest seasons – many parts – around Jan. 14
- Map – diff. names – similar festivals – across India – same date



An Epic Spread

- Literature – another display – unity in diversity – Indian literature – very diverse
- Over centuries – diff. in lang., tech., etc. – shared imp. themes, concerns
- Panchatantra – animals – main characters – teaches us – imp. life skills
- This original Sanskrit text – 2200+ yrs. old – BUT – stories – adapted – almost every Indian lang.
- These stories – travel a lot – Southeast Asia, Arab world, Europe – inspiring new collections – estimated – 200+ adaptations – 50+ lang.
- Most striking case – India's 2 epics – Ramayana, Mahabharata
- 2 long Sanskrit poems – together – 7000+ pages – original versions – narrate stories – heroes fighting – re-establish Dharma
 - Mahabharata – Pandavas – with Krishna's help – fight own cousins – Kauravas – recover kingdom
 - Ramayana – Rama – with Lakshmana and Hanuman – defeat Ravana – kidnapped Rama's wife Sita
- These stories – many shorter ones – focus on values
- More than 2 millenniums – these 2 epics – translated, adapted – regional literatures – India and beyond – additionally – countless folk versions
- Few yrs. ago – scholar – survey – Tamil Nadu – 100+ versions of Mahabharata – folklore forms
- Many communities – own versions – Ramayana, Mahabharata
- Also preserved – legends – connecting their history – these epics
- Specially in tribal communities – Bhils, Gonds, Mundas, etc.
- India's northeast, Himalayan regions – own versions – 2 epics
- Tribal adaptations – transmitted orally – along with – legends – heroes – 2 epics – visited tribes' regions
- Anthropologist – K. S. Singh – directed – 'Project of India'
- Mahabharata – he obs. – no place in India – Pandavas – did not visit – a/c to folklore – same for Ramayana
- Over centuries – these 2 epics – created – dense web – cultural interactions – across India and Asia
- India's classical arts – diversity and unity – easily noticeable
- Indian culture – celebrates diversity – enrichment – BUT – never lose sight – underlying unity – nourishes the diversity